

# Common Scams & Preventive tips

Understand how the different types of scams tactics works and how to better protect yourself and avoid falling for it.

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## Impersonation scam

Scammers may pose as:



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- Government official
  - Bank Officers
  - Your family and friends

In the government official impersonation scam variant, the victim would first receive an unsolicited call from a scammer impersonating a bank officer. The scammer would then ask the victim to verify banking transactions that the victim had allegedly conducted via their bank accounts.

When the victim denies knowledge of such transactions, the scammer would transfer the call to a second scammer who would pose as a government official. The second scammer would accuse the victim of being involved in criminal activities such as money laundering and ask the victim to transfer monies to specified bank accounts under the pretext of assisting in investigations. The scammers would assure the victims that the accounts were 'safety accounts' designated by the government. In some cases, the victim is transferred to a third scammer for 'further investigations' and asked to transfer more monies to specified bank accounts.

Victims would only realize that they had been scammed when the scammers become uncontactable or when they subsequently verify the situation with the banks or authorities through official channels.

### Scam prevention tips:

- Be vigilant when receiving messages from other parties especially if you do not recognize the social media account they are using to contact you
- Do not click on suspicious links provided in unsolicited SMSes and emails
- Never disclose your personal or internet banking details and one-time passwords (OTPs) to anyone
- When in doubt, verify the authenticity of the party
- Government officials will never ask members of the public to transfer money to bank accounts or request for their personal banking or SingPass details

Beware of scammers creating fake social media accounts and fraudulent websites pretending to be us.

Remember that while HSBC might reach out directly to confirm your transactions, banking requests or ask for details such as your name and your identification number for identification purposes, HSBC will never request for your bank account login credentials through embedded hyperlinks, QR codes, email, text or any messaging/ social media



We will only communicate all information on our promotions, products and services through our official channels.

Always verify before you engage, our official channels are:

Instagram: @hsbc\_sg

Facebook: [facebook.com/HSBCSingapore](https://www.facebook.com/HSBCSingapore)

LinkedIn: [linkedin.com/company/hsbc/](https://www.linkedin.com/company/hsbc/)

YouTube: @HSBC\_SG

Website: Access banking services by typing <https://www.hsbc.com.sg> into the browser search bar.

## Investment scam

Investment scams claim to offer high returns for very little risk. Fraudsters often use false testimonials, fake celebrity endorsements, spoof websites, cloned companies and other marketing materials to make the scams appear genuine. If it seems too good to be true, it generally is. If you're investing in cryptocurrency, make sure you conduct your own research and understand the offer and how investment and trading works.

### Ways to spot an investment scam

- You're approached by phone, email, text message or by someone calling at your house with an investment opportunity
- The 'company' contacting you won't allow you to call back
- You feel pressured into making a quick decision, for example if the caller states the offer is 'only available right now' or 'don't miss out'
- The only contact you're given is a mobile phone number
- It seems too good to be true – high returns for a low risk

### Fake interest rate scam

In this variant of investment scams, the scammers send text messages to victims presenting a "time-limited" offer of a term-deposit account with an interest rate that is approximately one to two percent higher than the market rates to lure the victims. After receiving a response, the perpetrators would then pose as banks' agents to persuade and harvest victim's information for the opening of the bank account as part of the promotion.



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victims would then be instructed to deposit money into these “holding” accounts and the perpetrators would dissuade the victims from verifying the accounts by claiming that these accounts were only meant to hold the funds before account creation or there was an “activation period”. The victim’s money would then be transferred out of the accounts by the scammers.

### Scam prevention tips:

- Never disclose your credentials and OTP to anyone
- When in doubt, verify the authenticity of the information with our official website or sources
- When it is too good to be true, think twice

## Ecommerce scam

Keep yourself safe on E-commerce platforms and watch out for an increase in phishing scams involving fake buyers.

These scammers can be found posing as potential buyers who will request for your contact details, seemingly to facilitate payment or make delivery arrangements. Depending on the details provided, you might receive an email, SMS, or Whatsapp message from the scammer with links or QR codes to spoofed websites that ask you to key in your banking credentials and OTPs to move forward with the sale. The scammers would then proceed to use your personal information provided to carry out unauthorized transactions from your bank accounts.

### Scam prevention tips:

- Always verify the buyer’s profile on online marketplaces by checking the account's verification status, creation date, reviews, and ratings
- Check the platforms you’re purchasing from; make sure to verify their domains and download their apps from the official app store, watch out for dubious practices such as odd URLs or links sent via SMS, and avoid entering your OTPs outside of the official app or site
- Keep communication with buyers within the platforms, especially in relation to payment matters and sharing of information



- Never disclose your personal or internet banking details and OTP to third parties

Report suspicious users and any fraudulent transactions to the platforms and your bank immediately.

## Social Engineering Scams

At HSBC, we take Online Security very seriously and we want to protect our customers as much as possible. That's why we are providing you with this important advice. While we have equipped HSBC Online Banking with industry standard security technology and practices to ensure that our customers are protected against fraud, you play an important part in protecting your account and transactions too.

**Phishing** – Criminals might also send you emails that look like they're from HSBC or other organisations you know well, to try to coax you into giving them your personal data. The links or QR codes embedded in these phishing emails will usually take you to a fake website that looks convincingly like the organization's real site, where you'll be asked to enter your personal information, credentials or security code.

Here are a few things to remember to avoid being phished:

- check for spelling errors
- make sure the sender's email address matches the company they claim to represent; avoid anything that seems long and complex
- if you followed an email link to the company's home page, look for the padlock symbol at the side of the address bar to know it's secure
- if an email or website somehow feels different from the regular ones you know from the organisation, err on the side of caution and don't click any links or download any of the attachments

**Vishing** - This is the telephone equivalent of phishing, which is an increasingly common form of phone fraud, with seemingly legitimate-looking phone numbers. A fraudster will call you and try to trick you into giving your private information. Be wary of anyone who calls you asking you to disclose information. If in doubt, always end the call and call us back. Anyone legitimately calling from HSBC will not be upset if you say you prefer to call us directly.



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- Lottery scam - The caller tells you that you have won a lottery or lucky draw and you need to pay a processing fee to collect the winnings
  - Kidnap scam - The caller tells you they've kidnapped a loved one and demands a ransom for their release
  - Impersonation Scam – The caller claims to be from the court or police (or other government agencies) and tells you that you need to pay a fine or informs you that you are a suspect in illegal activities
  - Loan Scam - The caller claims to be a staff from a licensed moneylender and tells you to transfer money as a deposit before the loan can be disbursed
  - Money Mule Scam – The caller tells you to open a bank account to receive or transfer money after gaining your trust, sometimes even offering you a portion of the money transferred as 'commission'

**Smishing** – SMS phishing is when you get a text message aimed at getting you to reveal your personal details. With so many of us always on our mobile phones, smishing can present a risk if we're not vigilant about checking links we get through text messaging platforms like WhatsApp.

In general, avoid replying to text messages from people you don't know or numbers you don't recognise and don't click on links you get on your phone unless you know the person they're coming from.

### Scam prevention tips:

- For safe and secured online banking, only access websites starting with [hsbc.com.sg](https://www.hsbc.com.sg), or enter the URL in the browser address bar directly
- Do not respond to any actions required from an unsolicited email
- Be aware that HSBC will never ask customers for such confidential banking data in their emails
- Do not respond to any emails that request such information or click on an embedded hyperlink
- Update your anti-virus software and use email client with two-factor authentication
- At logon, do not enter any numbers generated from the internet into your Digital Secure Key/Security Device. HSBC will never provide you with any numbers or beneficiary-related information onscreen to input into your Digital Secure Key/Security Device to generate a security code



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Fraudsters use fake emails and websites to get you to unknowingly give away your passwords or bank details. Look out for these warning signs to spot them.

- Poor design, typos or bad grammar
- The sender's email address doesn't match the name of the company domain it's meant to be coming from
- Asking you to do something unusual
- Asking for personal information
- An email link that says it's going somewhere that it isn't (tip: hover over a link in an email to see its real destination)
- A website that doesn't display the padlock symbol in their address bar when you log in

### Prevention tips:

- Don't download any free software on your computer unless you're certain it's safe
- Use anti-virus software, and make sure it's up-to-date
- Change your passwords regularly
- Don't respond to unsolicited emails requesting information, and don't follow any links in them either
- Make sure you're on a secure website before submitting banking or other sensitive information. Secure websites begin with 'https://' instead of 'http://'. They'll also contain a padlock icon on the address bar

### Phishing:

To report phishing websites, smishing texts or suspicious emails which have requested personal banking information, contact us via [phishing@hsbc.com](mailto:phishing@hsbc.com). We'll send you an automatic response to let you know we've received your email but are unable to provide personalised responses to this mailbox.

## Job scam

The victims would receive unsolicited WhatsApp or Telegram messages asking them to participate in a survey or market research and to answer a few questions. The questions



After victims were convinced that they could earn commission, scammers would provide another WhatsApp or Telegram contact to the victims, suggesting that the victims could reach out to the contact for more rewarding jobs. The scammers would ask the victims to perform tasks such as “boosting” the value of cryptocurrencies or “rating” mobile applications to improve their rankings on app stores. To perform these tasks, victims had to create accounts on scam websites and transfer monies to bank accounts provided by the scammers. In some cases, victims would be instructed by scammers to put in even more of their own money for a variety of reasons. Victims would realize that they had been scammed when they failed to withdraw their commission or when the scammers could no longer be contacted.

### Prevention tips:

1. Stop and think if the deal is too good to be true.
2. Do not rush into providing your personal or banking details.
3. Speak to others to verify the authenticity of a claim before doing anything.
4. Never disclose personal information, even if the request appears to be legitimate.

## Tech support scam

Technical support scams are when fraudsters pretend to be representatives from trusted tech companies. Fraudster use scare tactics to deceive victims by falsely claiming there is an issue with their device or software (e.g., service suspension, illegal activity detected etc.). If victims continue to engage with fraudsters, they will be asked for a fee or subscription to a purported support service. In some cases, fraudsters may further attempt to gain remote access and install malware for stealing data.

Some fraudsters have also used urgent pop-ups displaying fake error notifications on browsers, aided with alarming sounds. This can be originated from fraudulent ads, compromised sites, scam websites etc. Fraudsters may also incorporate phishing tactics by sending victims emails, texts, or messages directing them to these webpages. To make it more convincing, they will put the image of error image on full screen, so that viewers will believe it was from the system instead of the webpage, and ultimately be persuaded to call the displayed tech support number.

### Scam prevention tips:





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- If you receive a call or email, verify the phone number and caller's identity through official channels and call back using the official number
  - Do not transfer money to unknown third parties
  - Only download and install software from trusted and verified official channels
  - Do not grant remote access to computers or share any personal financial info; credentials or transaction signing codes

## Romance Scam

Met a new partner or friend online? Are they unable to meet in person? If they ask you to send them money, it could be a fraudster using a fake identity to scam you.

Scammers set up fake profiles on dating sites or social media, and build 'relationships' with victims who think they're talking to a real person. They build trust, often over months of chatting and even phone calls. There's usually a believable reason they can't meet in person and play on your emotions to trick you into sending them money.

A scammer you've only met online might ask you for money and say things like:

- They are abroad and need money for travel to visit you
- They have a sick relative who needs medical care
- They have a business problem and need a loan to tide them over
- They're waiting for an inheritance but need funds to access their money

Prevention tips:

- Never send money to someone you haven't met in person. They might not be who they say they are
- Be wary of new contacts or friend requests
- Don't share financial details
- Check in with family or friends you know in person for a second opinion

## Malware



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computer viruses and spyware.

Such malware is capable of obtaining a customer's internet banking credentials (Username, Password and Security Code) once it resides in the device that is used to access the Online Banking services.

You may experience the following if you have accessed your internet banking from an infected computer:

- See a screen with a 'Please wait....' message
- Prompted repeatedly to enter your username, password or security code
- "Slowness" in your computer while accessing internet banking
- Prompted to input the number provided onscreen into your Digital Secure Key/Security Device to generate a Security Code
- Irregularities during your internet banking session (e.g. banking website redirecting to 3rd party website offering hotline number, altered login flow and unsolicited requests for tokens)

## Spyware

Spyware is a computer software program that gathers information about a computer user, in most cases without the user's knowledge or informed consent. It transmits the collected information to an organisation or person who can potentially manipulate the information.

Such software program may claim to be able to speed up your internet connections, but in fact redirects your internet session through their own servers. This could mean that the Spyware has the ability to gain access to your passwords, PINs, credit card numbers and other personal transactional details.

Spyware is not the same as a virus in that it only records what you do rather than altering how your machine works. Because of this, anti-virus software is not effective in identifying and removing spyware. In order to find out if spyware is present on your device, it is necessary to download and run specific anti-spyware programs.

We strongly recommend that you install and use a reputable product to protect against the possible security threats of spyware on your devices.

## Prevention tips:

- To prevent the spyware installation without your consent, remember not to download any freeware onto the computer that you access internet banking with



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download other programs or open e-mails

- If you think that you have installed such software in your device, you may wish to seek professional IT advice on steps to be taken to uninstall the software from your PC
- Avoid using "Public" Computer to access your Online Banking
- Do not download or open any attachments in suspicious emails
- Install and update your anti-virus software, personal firewall and security patches
- Always download apps from official app stores

If you notice anything suspicious, terminate your internet banking session immediately and get in touch with us to verify. Do not proceed with the transaction and have your computer scanned immediately for malware.

For more info relating to Malware, click [here](#).

## Card Fraud

Card fraud is a commonly known issue and has been on the rise. The industry has reported a number of cards and PINs being compromised, resulting in unauthorised cash withdrawals on customers' debit and credit cards.

Fraudsters are able to acquire PINs and electronic data from the black strip of the bank card, possibly during cash withdrawals at ATMs. Afterwards, counterfeit cards are used to withdraw money from customers' accounts. To safeguard yourself against card fraud, refrain from using cards with magnetic strip authentication. This is especially so for standalone ATMs at remote locations.

Also be vigilant especially when you hand your cards over for payments at restaurants or during travels.

Call us immediately at +65 6-HSBC NOW (6-4722 669) if you suspect that a fraudulent activity has occurred in your account. This includes your OTP, Card or account details being compromised.

### Additional Prevention Tips:

Install ScamShield from your official app store to enhance your protection.

ScamShield is an app developed by the National Crime Prevention Council (NCPC), in collaboration with Open Government Products (OGP), a division of the Government



- Check for scams
- Block and filter scams
- Report potential scams

If you are unsure if it is a scam, call the 24/7 ScamShield Helpline (1799) to check.

Find more information on ScamShield at: <https://www.scamshield.gov.sg/>

We also regularly post warnings about common scams on our social media channels. Do keep a lookout for our postings to avoid being a victim of a scam.

## You might be interested in

### HSBC Safeguard >

Learn more about our initiative to safeguard your hard-earned money from financial crime.

### Secure online payments >

Stay safe when you do your banking online with the HSBC Digital Secure Key/Security Device.

### Unrecognised transaction? >

If you suspect there's been fraud on your account, find out your next steps.

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### Connect with us >

Listening to what you have to say about services matters to us. It's easy to share your ideas, stay informed and join the conversation.



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